

The 10-Step Budget Checklist

STEP 1 — KNOW WHAT'S COMING IN

- ☐ List every income source (job, side income, benefits)
- ☐ Use your lowest recent month as your baseline — not the best one
- ☐ Separate guaranteed income from variable income

STEP 2 — TRACK EVERY FIXED EXPENSE

- ☐ Rent or mortgage
- ☐ Utilities (electric, water, internet, phone)
- ☐ Insurance (health, car, renters/home)
- ☐ Subscriptions (streaming, software, gym — list every single one)
- ☐ Minimum debt payments (credit cards, loans, student debt)

STEP 3 — TRACK VARIABLE SPENDING

- ☐ Groceries (use last 3 months average)
- ☐ Gas or transport
- ☐ Dining out and coffee
- ☐ Entertainment and hobbies
- ☐ Personal care and clothing

STEP 4 — FIND THE GAP

- ☐ Income minus fixed expenses minus variable spending = your gap
- ☐ If the gap is negative, you have a spending problem — not an income problem
- ☐ If the gap is positive, decide where it goes before it disappears

STEP 5 — ASSIGN EVERY DOLLAR

- ☐ Set a savings target first — pay yourself before anything else
- ☐ Build a \$1,000 emergency buffer before investing
- ☐ Allocate remaining gap to debt payoff or goals
- ☐ Zero-based budget: income minus all assignments = \$0

STEP 6 — CUT THE OBVIOUS WASTE

- ☐ Cancel any subscription you haven't used in 30 days
- ☐ Call your phone and insurance providers and ask for a loyalty discount
- ☐ Switch any variable bill you haven't reviewed in 12 months

STEP 7 — PICK YOUR TOOL AND COMMIT

- ☐ Choose one budgeting method and stick with it for 90 days
- ☐ YNAB if you want to change behavior — not just track it
- ☐ Rocket Money if subscriptions are eating your budget
- ☐ A spreadsheet if you want full control with no monthly fee

STEP 8 — REVIEW WEEKLY FOR 4 WEEKS

- ☐ Set a 15-minute weekly money check-in
- ☐ Compare actual spending to planned spending
- ☐ Adjust next week based on what went wrong this week
- ☐ After 4 weeks it stops feeling like a chore

STEP 9 — AUTOMATE WHAT YOU CAN

- ☐ Automate savings transfer on payday
- ☐ Set bill autopay for fixed expenses
- ☐ Use a separate account for variable spending so you can see the balance

STEP 10 — CHECK YOUR NET WORTH QUARTERLY

- ☐ Assets minus liabilities = net worth
- ☐ Track it every 3 months — not daily
- ☐ A rising net worth means the budget is working even when it doesn't feel like it